

SAN SEBASTIAN SPAIN

Basque Coast Innovation

Napoleon sacked and burned San Sebastián in 1813, but the resort that rose from the ashes is the epitome of refined hedonism. Royalty and movie stars bask in the sizzle of the Spanish sun, while San Sebastián's Basque chefs demonstrate the innovative Modern Spanish cuisine that has raised the bar for European gastronomy, much as Picasso rewrote the rules for modern art.



Playa de la Concha, San Sebastián's main beach, nestles between the twin headlands of Monte Urgull and Monte Igeldo. Its 4-mile (6-km) swath of white sand makes the city the pearl of the Basque coast. Once the sun goes down, beach-goers wash off their tanning lotion, dress for dinner, and prepare for an evening at the tables of San Sebastián's world-class restaurants. The city has more Michelin three-star establishments per capita than Paris or Tokyo, and a host of wonderful cafés, taverns, and bars where the quality of the food belies the humble surroundings.

San Sebastián is an intriguing mix of the old and the new. The broad avenues of the sophisticated modern town, lined with upmarket shops and restaurants, give way to the atmospheric streets of the old town beneath the base of Monte Urgull. Centered around the ancient Plaza de la Constitución, these narrow lanes hide treats such as the church of Santa Maria del Coro, a masterly example of Basque Baroque. The old town's sheltered harbor curls around a series of

stone embankments, where a small fishing fleet unloads its rich daily catch of bream, sardines, anchovies, shrimp, spider crab, mullet, monkfish, and hake. The Basques are legendary fishermen and inventive cooks – Basque cuisine was a culinary revolution waiting to happen. With its emphasis on perfect ingredients artfully presented, Basque cooking proved the perfect foil to French nouvelle cuisine.

When San Sebastián's chefs began bringing theater to the plate in the 1970s, they championed local produce, fish, and meat, and jettisoned the elaborate, time-intensive preparations of traditional *haute cuisine*. They had fired the opening salvo of Modern Spanish cuisine – and have wowed diners ever since. They experiment with flavors like an artist expanding his palette, endowing each plate with an element of surprise. But the emphasis here is on flavor rather than culinary pyrotechnics: parsley foam brings out the sweetness of spider crab steeped in spicy tomato sauce; a sprinkling of crispy garlic wafers provides a crunchy counterpoint to pan-fried codfish with clams. Every dish is a sublime medley of texture and tastes.

Basque Wines

There are two distinctive wine regions in the Basque lands of Spain: the **Rioja Alavesa**, where the famous bodega of Marqués de Riscal is based; and the **Basque coast**, where the Txakolí wines are produced. The red Tempranillo and Cabernet Sauvignon blends of **Rioja** are justly famous as bold accompaniments to roasted meats and hearty stews. The mostly white, often slightly fizzy **Txakolí** wines are characterized by a bracing acidity that makes them the perfect foil for Basque seafood. Although Txakolí has been cultivated for at least 1,200 years, it has been the Basques' carefully guarded secret, and did not enter the export market until the 21st century. Three Txakolí districts are recognized, but the pale yellow to green wines from **Getaria** and **Zarautz** on the coast between Bilbao and San Sebastián are considered the best.



Above Basque Michelin three-star chef Juan Mari Arzak and his daughter Elena



The Best Places to Eat Modern Spanish Cuisine

Restaurante Arzak expensive

One could say that Juan Mari Arzak got his revenge on Napoleon by launching Modern Spanish cuisine – a revolution that toppled French *haute cuisine* from its gastronomic throne. This was Spain's first restaurant to be awarded three Michelin stars, and eating at Arzak remains as exciting today as it was in the 1970s, when the unknown provincial chef first applied the principles of French nouvelle cuisine to the traditions of Basque cookery. Arzak reduces dishes to their essential flavors, then plates them with unfussy but witty theater. Now working with his daughter Elena, Arzak continues to experiment with new twists on familiar foods – his “perfect egg” dishes are legendary among Spanish chefs – without sacrificing the integrity of the ingredients or the surprise of the presentation. Most diners opt for the astonishing tasting menu, which allows the broadest experience of Arzak's creative and experimental approach. It begins with a half-dozen or so small dishes, explodes into three to four “main” dishes built around meat or fish, and then segues into a series of sweet and delicious surprises.

Avenida Alcalde José Elorsequi 273, San Sebastián; open for lunch Tue–Fri, dinner Tue–Sat; www.arzak.es

Also in San Sebastián

Pedro Subijana is the master magician of **Akelare** (www.relaischateaux.com; *expensive*), where mountainside views of the Bay of Biscay match his culinary sleight of hand. Martín Berasategui crafts a roller coaster of flavor surprises at his flagship **Berasategui** (www.martinberasategui.com; *expensive*) while offering an affordable sampling of his free-form imagination at **Restaurante Kursaal** (+34 943 003 162; *moderate*).

Also in Spain

In Madrid, diners greet dishes at **Villa Magna by Eneko Atxa** (www.villamagna.es; *moderate*) with either a hearty laugh or an exclamation of delight. At **Sergi Arola Gastro** (www.sergiarola.es; *expensive*), also in Madrid, Catalan star chef Sergi Arola composes just a few strong flavors per plate, cooking much like fellow Catalan Joan Miró painted. Innovator Ferran Adrià's greatest hits form the menu at **Hacienda Benazuza** (www.elbullihotel.com; *expensive*), in Sanlúcar la Mayor, near Seville.

Around the World

Spanish-born and trained, José Andrés launched a craze for Modern Spanish cuisine in the US. His most theatrical and magical restaurant, **The Bazaar** (www.thebazaar.com; *moderate*), in Beverly Hills, California, won *Esquire* magazine's Restaurant of the Year award in 2009.